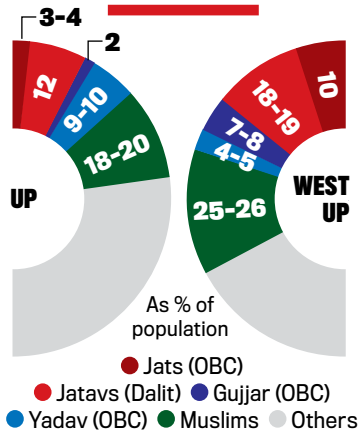
connects with us. If the youth come together under one fold, we can defeat the BJP," says Jayant.

Politics in the western districts of Uttar Pradesh has revolved principally around the Jat-Jatav caste dynamics. The schisms between the two social groups have always cast a shadow on politics in the region but now unemployment, inflation and several other local factors are bringing them together. And as Jayant himself admitted, a crucial factor in this was also the support of Azad's Bhim Army. At a time when Mayawati's BSP has lost its sheen, he has emerged as the rising star of Dalit politics, especially among the youth. Azad believes the alliance worked well as he and Jayant are from western UP, and understand the problems of the region. "Together, we'll take the fight ahead," he says. "This time the results changed because our social coalition worked well."

Dr Shilp Shikha Singh, a UP-based political analyst and assistant professor at the Giri Institute of Development Studies, says, "Jats are a big community in west UP but their presence is mainly in a dozen districts and their dominance is in six, including Muzzaffarnagar, Shamli, Meerut, Baghpat, Hathras and Bulandshahr. On the other hand,

THE CASTE MATRIX



MAHARASHTRA/UDDHAV THACKERAY

A CHANGE OF IMAGE

By Dhaval Kulkarni

These days, Uddhav Thackeray is visible! On December 17, the Shiv Sena (Uddhav Balasaheb Thackeray) president walked for over 3 km in the morcha organised by the Maharashtra Vikas Aghadi (MVA) over issues like comments against social icons by governor B.S. Koshyari.

"One of the messages of this morcha is that Uddhav Thackeray is in good health. His participation in this long march has also scotched any rumours about this," explains a senior Congress leader. Thackeray's aides say that he will also undertake a statewide tour early next year to rally his forces. Similarly, his son and former environment minister Aaditya Thackeray has toured parts of the state. The former CM also attended the winter session of the state legislature at Nagpur and spoke in the legislative council on December 26 about Maharashtra's border dispute with Karnataka.

Over the last few months, Thackeray has also visited parts of Aurangabad district (October), which were affected by unseasonal rains, and held a public meeting at Chikhli in Vidarbha's Buldhana district (November). Thackeray has also been meeting party workers at his residence 'Matoshri' or the party headquarters—Shiv Sena Bhavan—and is inducting leaders from other parties.

This sudden public outreach is aimed at stemming any further damage to the otherwise monolithic organisation and capitalising on any sympathy among the masses after his government was ousted. As chief minister in the MVA regime, Thackeray's lack of accessibility and hands-off approach were seen as reasons for the discontent in the Shiv Sena reaching disruptive levels. This culminated in the midnight coup that toppled his government.

Now, as the Shiv Sena licks its wounds after a mauling by former leader and incumbent chief minister Eknath Shinde and the BJP, Thackeray seems to have hit the ground running. "The credit (for Thackeray's public activity) goes to Shinde. We must give credit where it is due," says a Shiv Sena source, speaking in a lighter vein.

Though the Shiv Sena is no stranger to splits since its inception in 1966, Shinde's mutiny is unlike that by rebels such as Bandu Shingre, Dr Hemchandra Gupte, Chhagan Bhujbal, Narayan Rane or even Raj Thackeray. For, Shinde, whose revolt in June brought down the MVA coalition, walked away with 39 other MLAs and 13 Lok Sabha MPs into the waiting arms of the BJP, leaving Thackeray with just 16 MLAs and six Lok Sabha MPs. The Shinde camp also laid claim to being the "real" Shiv Sena. The resultant battle in the Election Commission saw the Shiv Sena's original name and bow-and-arrow symbol being frozen.

This forced the Thackeray-led party to take on the name of Shiv Sena (Uddhav Balasaheb Thackeray) and the *mashaal* (flaming torch) symbol. Shinde named his breakaway group 'Balasahebanchi Shiv Sena' and has taken



ON FRONT FOOT
Thackeray at a protest march in Mumbai

ANI

the *dhaal-talwar* (shield with sheathed swords) symbol. Put together, this has created an existential crisis of sorts for the "original" Shiv Sena.

Thackeray's party colleagues admit that their litmus test will be holding on to power in the Mumbai civic body, which is the richest in India. The Shiv Sena has controlled the Brihanmumbai Municipal Corporation (BMC) for the past 25 years (since 1997). This helps the party nurture its